

Something Happened While Nobody Was Looking: The Growth of International Education and the Chinese Learner

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In the rapidly globalizing world of the late twentieth and early twenty-first centuries, where money, ideas, and people move readily across the planet, it has become clear that the circulation of knowledge plays an increasingly critical part in economic productivity, potentially spelling problems for those who cannot share in this linkage and presenting opportunities for those who can:

Educational systems tied to the formation of nation-state citizens and consumers bonded to local systems to the neglect of larger global forces are likely to become obsolete, while those that proactively engage globalization's new challenges are more likely to thrive. (Suárez-Orozco and Qin-Hilliard 2004, 23)

In becoming part of the global economy, China wants to share in the most effective strategies of international education for its people at home and abroad. It is the development of international education and the impact on Chinese learners that I would like to take up in this chapter, which forms the basis for the rest of this volume's considerations about the Chinese learner at home and abroad and in schools and universities.

Recognizing the force of globalization and the need for basic education, international leaders as far back as the mid-twentieth century created strategies and guidelines to make educational opportunities available worldwide, so that individuals and countries could participate in, and enjoy the benefits of, globalization:

In 1948 the Universal Declaration of Human Rights proclaimed free and compulsory education to be a basic human right. In 1990 the World Conference on Education for All, held in Jomtien, Thailand, pledged to

provide primary education for all by 2000; this pledge was reaffirmed in Dakar, Senegal, in 2000. In 2000 the United Nations Millennium Development Goals promised universal completion of primary education by 2015. And in 2002 the Plan of Implementation that emerged from the World Summit on Sustainable Development in Johannesburg highlighted the central role of education in promoting good health, environmental protection, and sustainable development. (Bloom 2004, 56)

Although these goals have yet to be fully realized, basic, primary-level education has advanced; internationally the 2002 enrollment rate in primary school stands nearly at 96 percent in developed countries, 89 percent in countries “in transition,” and 83 percent in developing countries. These regions include Central Asia, East Asia, Europe, and the Americas. In fact, of all regions, only in Sub-Saharan Africa at 63.5 percent does the rate actually go below 82.6 percent (UNESCO 2005, 44). The proportion of students in secondary schools has also risen above 90 percent in developed industrial countries and those in transition, although some developing countries still fall below 70 percent (UNESCO 2005, 52). As noted by the *World Development Report* (2007), because a high correlation exists between educational achievement and economic compensation, it is worrisome that any country falls short of full literacy at primary and secondary levels (World Bank 1).

Access to basic education and secondary schooling has been identified as an urgent international issue and studied by educators, governmental agencies, and NGOs across the globe. What has not been so well studied, however, is the demand for high-quality education that can nurture excellence and give an academic, economic, and social “edge” in this age of intense global business, politics, and education. Not long ago, the *South China Morning Post* produced a so-called “white paper,” “Enhancing the Quality of Hong Kong’s Education,” which argued that Hong Kong lacks mechanisms “to overhaul or weed out under-performers” among local schools because they are products of vested administrators, pedagogy, and funding. The answer to this, maintained the report, was a system that mirrored the English Schools Foundation (ESF) and international schools in promoting excellence across the board (“Facts” 2006, E5). As Chris Forse points out (Chapter 3, in this book), the ESF system has grown exponentially in Hong Kong because Chinese parents perceive it as giving high-quality education in the English medium with good access to Western universities. Hong Kong is not alone in thinking that international education may be a better alternative than local education. At about the same time as the *South China Morning Post* report, the *International Herald Tribune* profiled “foreign-run schools” in China as an alternative to local schools because of their liberal curriculum and English-language teaching (Pocha 2006, 4). These observations from Hong Kong and

mainland China voice a growing sentiment that, although learning is a “socially situated activity” deeply embedded in particular locations (Rao and Chan 2009, 14), “national education systems seem to be in a perpetual state of crisis (Phillips 2002, 159) and that high-quality international education has evolved well beyond them, preferred by expatriates and locals alike:

The economic rise of Asia and other parts of [the] developing world and the growth of international commerce have drawn millions of people to the expatriate life, and they have brought their children with them. Prosperity in developing countries is also manifesting itself in higher educational aspirations among local people. Many want their children to benefit from the better quality education and college opportunities available within the international school system. (Greenlees 2006, 18)

These comments, while particularly focused on the advantages of international schools, are strong indications that much more study needs to be given to the effects of globalization on education in schools and universities, the ways in which localization has worked against global understanding in education, and the impact of internationalization on students, in particular Chinese learners, at home and abroad. Economists and politicians have followed the flow of money and tracked political ideologies, and sociologists have researched the movement of migrants and culture from rural to urban environments and from Asia to the West, but most have paid too little attention to the radical changes in internationalized education and its effects on Asian learners.

In the first part of the chapter, I will discuss traditional education situated in the local, regional, and national. Then, I will talk about education as it goes global, with some of the first hints of the magnitude of the change seen in the OECD’s comparison of student examination results country by country as well as rapidly multiplying international rankings of universities. Next, I will talk about the escalation of boarding and international schools, International Baccalaureate programs (IB), and international exchanges of university students and faculty members. Finally, I will address the education of the Chinese learners in their home environments, as well as the current Diaspora from rural to urban areas in China and from one part of the world to another. These are the contexts and among the most important challenges and opportunities for education in the twenty-first century.

Education — curriculum, funding, and assessment: A local and national issue

Traditionally, education has been tied to local and national cultures, policies, and funding. Schools in almost every country are funded through city and county taxes

and are expected to reflect the priorities and values of the local citizenry. States, provinces, and regions usually govern the production and qualitative review of curriculum to establish a common basis for education in a particular society. In some countries, the central government itself well may oversee the formation and evaluation of curriculum and establish national examinations to ensure that there is consistency of curriculum, approach, and standards in schools across the nation, but in other countries these are local and regional concerns. Almost never — except under various colonial enterprises — has there been any attempt for representatives of one country to oversee the curriculum and educational practices of another, for education is designed for particular electorates, speaks to local social values, and arises from national interests and ideologies.

Universities often escape local governmental oversight, but they, too, are subject to similar principles of region and nation. In Australia, Canada, and the United States, states and provinces fund, and are responsible for, the quality of the universities as the practice of naming suggests — University of South West Wales, University of Alberta, and University of Pennsylvania. Though universities in Australia also receive recurrent funding from the Federal Government as do particular university initiatives in Canada and the United States, rarely do governments at the highest levels oversee all of tertiary education, so that, while there are national philosophies of education, the responsibility for funding and implementing these remains at a relatively local level. This principle is true in the East as well as the West, though in China majority funding often comes from the cities in which the universities are located. This practice is especially common in the larger, wealthier, globalized cities of Beijing, Guangzhou, Nanjing, and Shanghai, where the cities have more money to spend on education than do regional or national governments. Still, the central government ranks universities and allocates special funding to help the most exemplary in the research field. In Denmark, the physical assets of the school — land and buildings — can be owned and operated by the local government, and only the educational structure itself (curriculum and teachers) funded by the central government. In short, the responsibilities for primary and secondary education are mainly local and regional, but governments at the highest level do get involved in university education to varying degrees.

Because schools, colleges, and universities are grounded locally and regionally, those who study education also tend to focus on the region and nation. Faculties of education in Hong Kong focus on the Hong Kong curriculum and local learners; those in Toronto focus on the province of Ontario and Canada; those in Sydney focus on New South Wales and Australia; and so it goes. An exception to this is the European Union, which is trying to alter the education systems of member states to build a comprehensive program with similar degrees, requirements, and

rates of progress throughout the entire European system. Even so, each country establishes its own educational objectives, goals, and programs. And, although educators around the world are interested in comparing the learning structures and practices of other countries, they rarely have a focus — or even multiple courses — on transnational, cross-cultural, and international education. As Australia, Canada, the UK, and the US have become more culturally and racially diverse, universities have taken greater note of special learner needs, inner-city challenges, and multiculturalism at the local levels as well as learning patterns and standards nationally, but the emphasis is almost always on the students adjusting to the local context and the teacher's expectations, not of the teachers having to adjust to the students' expectations or having to rethink pedagogy to accommodate new kinds of students from different national and cultural backgrounds.

Assessments within — and of — educational systems at all levels have consequently been carried out either locally or nationally. Often, students in the primary and secondary schools take state, provincial, or national exams to gauge their progress over the entire system or compete for admission into preferred tertiary institutions. Rarely are there published comparisons or rankings of primary and secondary schools either within the public or private domain. Still, universities often have their own rankings of schools for the purpose of deciding who gets admitted to their programs. They construct these independently and very privately.

Universities themselves have been subject to comparative national scrutiny for a number of years. In the early years, the scrutiny took the form of accreditation exercises and nation-based rankings with empirical statistics about the distinctiveness of the programs; the number, quality, geographical distribution, and acceptance of applicants; and the number of PhDs teaching within the institution and their quality of teaching and research. The exercises also included some appraisal of the physical structures and library holdings; and comments about staff salaries and endowments. They were based in part on reputational surveys of educators, administrators, students (past, present, and prospective), and business leaders. These were used widely as evaluations of the colleges and universities and as advertisements for programs, and the application rates of individual institutions rose or fell depending on these evaluations, so that rankings themselves became part of the business climate.

The United States had some of the earliest university rankings, appearing in various books and magazines dedicated to that purpose. The first of the university rankings, in the *US News and World Report*, appeared in 1983. In Canada, *Maclean's Magazine* has published a ranking of Canadian public universities for some fifteen years. (There are only a very few small private universities in Canada.) Even the European Commission has gotten into the act since 2003,

publishing a ranking of some twenty-two European universities — by no means the entire list. These rankings suggest that people have become increasingly concerned about the relative importance of their educational systems nationally. As people traversed the United States in pursuit of jobs and education in the second half of the twentieth century, they wanted to know the comparative value of programs, colleges, and universities.

Education: Symptoms and signs of internationalization

Although faculties of education as well as magazines and books of university rankings first concentrated on their own regions, the world in general has become interested in the comparative achievements of national educational systems. There are many signs that this is happening through international assessments and symptoms of emerging international perspectives on teaching and learning. This has been one of the first signs of a new internationalization and globalization of learning.

Another of these signs is the decision of the Organization for Economic Cooperation and Development (OECD) to study and foster good education in its member states: Australia, Austria, Belgium, Canada, Czech Republic, Denmark, Finland, France, Germany, Greece, Hungary, Iceland, Ireland, Italy, Japan, Korea, Luxembourg, Mexico, Netherlands, New Zealand, Norway, Poland, Portugal, Slovak Republic, Spain, Sweden, Switzerland, Turkey, the United Kingdom, and the United States. It has gone through massive amounts of social and educational data to determine what has been happening to education in these member states across the globe.

The OECD's purpose is not just to study the relation between education and society but to encourage better theory and practice that will bring societies along economically. Consequently, in 2000 it implemented the Program for International Student Assessment (PISA) to assess "the skills and knowledge of 15-year-olds" in reading literacy, mathematics literacy, and science literacy and to judge "whether students approaching the end of compulsory education have acquired the knowledge and skills that are essential for full participation in society" (Statistics Canada 2007, 1). "Full participation in society" means not just within each country alone but internationally across the organization's thirty member countries and selected partner countries and regions. PISA administers examinations every three years, and in each cycle focuses upon one primary skill, e.g., mathematics in 2006. PISA is not interested in the construction of the national curricula per se but how countries compare on issues that relate most directly to economic competitiveness, including, as mentioned above, mathematics, reading and science — those subjects considered the most

critical in any school system, the best indicators of success in further secondary and university education, and the most essential to economic development. Consequently, its findings on set examinations, calculation of the percentage of the students that enter and graduate from university, and tally of the number who study such fields as science, engineering, and teaching lead to conclusions about a country's comparative standing in education and ability to compete economically on an international scale.

This new agency formed at the cusp of the twenty-first century is interesting because it indicates a sudden awareness that countries no longer live in an education cocoon and proof that similar, if not the same, examinations can be given to hundreds of thousands of students across the world and educational results tabulated and compared, with serious implications about strategies for educating students nationally and internationally. This is only one of several indications that countries are beginning to recognize that the internationalization of education is every bit as important as globalization in economics and politics — indeed that the production of knowledge is the most important single factor in a country's ability to compete internationally in this growing knowledge economy.

The results of questionnaires and examinations from the OECD have, I think, been encouraging and surprising at the same time. For example, they indicate that more students are finishing secondary and tertiary education internationally than had been the case previously, though the United States has fallen behind as East Asia and Central Asia have risen. In this age of global migration, although first-generation migrants tend not to do so well in schools as their locally born counterparts, second-generation migrants do better than the local population. And, although the number of females educated in non-globalizing countries remains behind that of males, almost universally in globalized and globalizing countries, females have overtaken males in school completion. Certain countries, too, have demonstrated that their education results are almost always consistently ahead of other countries. Finland, Hong Kong, Korea, Norway, and Canada have emerged as model countries with excellence across the literacy spectrum and, given all of their strong economies, establishing the firm relationship between high literacy and monetary compensation. There are other countries as well that come out highly, but this mixture indicates that learners from the West and the East are recognized for their abilities across the spectrum and that educators do not have to follow stereotypes identifying one ethnic group as superior to others in mathematics and science abilities or inferior in reading literacy. They also indicate that both the East and the West have countries that are markedly superior in educating the young when the systems are well funded, and both have some that do not come up to the benchmark.

Arguably, this comparison of results in the testing of 15-year-olds is helpful in countries thinking about improving the education and scores of their students, for they can evaluate differing educational and funding models. However, another kind of comparison is at work at the university level with completely different motivations. At one time, recognition of universities' academic standing was largely nation-based and even nationalistic, reflecting not just academics but the age of the university, its endowment funds, and its country of origin. The English Oxbridge universities (Oxford and Cambridge) as well as the American Ivy League schools (especially Harvard, Yale, and Princeton) and a few of the American top state universities (e.g., University of California, Berkeley, and University of Michigan) always came out on top reputationally. In the English-language world, only the UK and the US tended to receive high recognition. As students began to move easily around the world in the late twentieth and early twenty-first centuries, looking for undergraduate programs for full-time study and yearly exchanges as well as reputable places for postgraduate education, various agencies began to compare universities and publish their results, changing the perception of universities across the world and recognizing those that had been overlooked before. The results of this barely decade-old phenomenon point to a new competition in international higher education as well as a commercialization of tertiary education as universities profit immensely from student applications and enrollment fees when they are listed in the top echelon internationally.

There are a host of recent surveys that signify this internationalizing of education, but the results are never consistent and vary widely depending on the criteria. Many look at specific kinds of programs (e.g., medicine and MBAs), while others rank universities more generally. Four such agencies, their announced methodologies, and rankings of the University of Hong Kong (HKU) give some idea of the wide, and even wild, variability in their conclusions. The Institute of Higher Education at Shanghai Jiao Tong University, for instance, began to publish its findings in 2003 and has recently said that it "considers every university that has any Nobel Laureates, Fields Medalists, and Highly Cited Researchers, or papers published in nature or science. In addition, universities with significant amount of papers indexed by Science Citation Index-Expanded (SCIE) and Social Science Citation Index (SSCI) are also included" ("Academic Ranking" 2008). With a bias clearly in the direction of sciences and social sciences, it did not rank HKU at all in the top 300 in 2007, though in 2006 it did rank it 263, and in 2008 somewhere between 201 and 300. "The Webometrics Ranking of World Universities," launched in 2004 and carried out by a large research group in Spain, ranked HKU 156 in 2007 on a wide-ranging basis of alumni surveys, faculty accomplishments, and research based on "bibliometric and scientometric indicators for the evaluation of the scientific performance of scholars and their

research groups” (Webometrics 2007). *The Times Educational Supplement* of the United Kingdom also publishes its survey of top universities called the “THES QS World University Rankings,” and, though its methods seem to be restricted to peer review, in 2009 ranked HKU number 24 of all the universities in the world. An Australian site, “Top 200 Universities and Colleges Worldwide,” ranks universities only on the basis of “web popularity,” that is, the number of hits that the university website gets, and on this basis, ranked HKU number 8 in 2007, though 84 in 2010. Consequently, in 2007 HKU went from a no-show to 156, to 18, to 8 all in one year, depending on the evaluating agency and criteria, and these statistics are just as varied in other years.

The purpose of my comments on the scoring of HKU is not just to show the wide variability of approaches and results but to indicate the high importance of international rankings of universities in this decade and the way that numbers of different agencies have recently entered this arena. International scrutiny and rankings have become extremely important in this age of globalization, and not only the universities themselves but countries such as Australia rely heavily on these surveys to attract students and maintain their university systems. Indeed, it has been claimed that mainland China has been the largest consumer of Australian resources and its children the largest consumers of Australian education.

This globalized university competition has recently taken an unprecedented leap. For the last quarter of a century, universities have been building international presence in locations abroad, usually — but not always — in conjunction with another local university to offer limited programs, engage in research, and assist with faculty and student exchanges. As a rule, universities with home bases in Australia, the UK, and the USA would fly in teachers for short-term courses and duties and hire a few local instructors on a contractual basis. Many courses were also offered online or through some form of distance education delivery system, so that the universities would not have to commit much human or financial capital. These would help raise the universities’ “profile, build international relationships, attract top research talent who, in turn, [might] attract grants and produce patents, and gain access to a new pool of tuition-paying students” (Lewin 2008a, 4).

Recently, American, Australian, British, and Canadian universities have started or expanded programs with partnerships in various countries in Asia, including China, India, Malaysia, and Singapore and have begun to open comprehensive branch campuses in the Middle East with teaching and administrative staff more or less permanently located onsite in facilities that belong to a particular university or that are shared by many. According to the *International Herald Tribune*, “at Education City in Doha, Qatar’s capital, they can study medicine at Weill Medical College of Cornell University, international affairs at Georgetown, computer science and business at Carnegie Mellon,

fine arts at Virginia Commonwealth, engineering at Texas A&M and, soon, journalism at Northwestern” (Lewin 2008a, 1). There are many questions about these operations, ranging from obvious ones about market-driven policies and administrative and financial viability to more complex ones about the impact of grafting one culture onto another, imposing Western ideology and social practices on non-Western cultures, and the intercultural, pedagogical, and ethical implications of mixing people, subject matter, and classroom behavior. It is too early to know how many of these new global university campuses will survive, but their very existence marks an important step in education and globalization.

School and university exchanges and boarding and international schools

The concern of the OECD, the examination results posted by PISA, the international rankings of universities, and the existence of international branch campuses all point to the increasing globalization of education. But the movement of university students from country to country, the popularity of exchange programs, the ongoing importance of boarding schools, the growth and quality of international schools, and the diasporas of Chinese learners indicate that education and globalization need to be reassessed with these phenomena in mind.

Until well after World War II, the vast majority of students stayed in their home countries for their primary, secondary, and tertiary education. In general, this is still true, but there is a sea change at the university level in students’ spending at least part of their education abroad. Many universities now require that students studying a foreign language take some study abroad in the country where that language is the medium of communication by native speakers, and many colleges and universities recommend, and even require, their students to have a semester or year abroad, regardless of discipline.

Although it is clear that the absolute numbers of students studying abroad has increased exponentially, it is not easy to get a grip on the actual figures because there is no international agency that monitors all of this movement and because, when countries do provide the figures, they sometimes do not indicate whether they are school or university students or both. While the majority of students studying abroad likely consists of university students, massive numbers of Chinese and Indian students, for example, now go to Australia and the UK for secondary schooling, and many of the students in international schools may not count as studying abroad because their entire families may have lived abroad for many years and they do not register statistically as going abroad for study.

Still, it is possible to get some sense of the scale of increases. According to the OECD, over 2.7 million students at the tertiary level went abroad in

2005 (“Education” 2007, 8, 45) and, according to the International Institute of Education (IIE), the USA was the primary destination (see Figure 1.1).

According to the IIE, in actual numbers, rather than percentages, the USA received 564,766 international students at the tertiary level in 2006. Of these students, 60 percent came from Asia, predominantly India (#1) and China (#2). During this year, 196,000 Americans studied at international universities. Moreover, again according to IIE, of students who went to the United Kingdom and Australia, the UK received 344,335 students in 2005, and Australia received 167,954 students in 2006. However, according to Australian Education International (2005), these figures could be considerably higher, and they suggest that Australia received 344,815 foreign enrollments in 2005 (“Recent” 2005). According to Ryan and Carroll (2005, 4), Australia predicts that this international study body will more than double to 810,000 by 2018, and the UK predicts 677,000 by 2015. According to the OECD, “international students are most numerous in tertiary enrollments in Australia, Austria, France, New Zealand, Switzerland and the United Kingdom” (“Education” 2007, 44)

Although in a 25-year period between 1978 and 2003, 580,000 undergraduate and postgraduate students from China went to the USA to study (Levin 2003, 8), in 2007 alone, according to the *China Daily*, 200,000 students from China went abroad (Wang 2008). IIE puts the number still higher, at 349,506 students from China even in 2004 — a significant variation in statistics, but in both cases

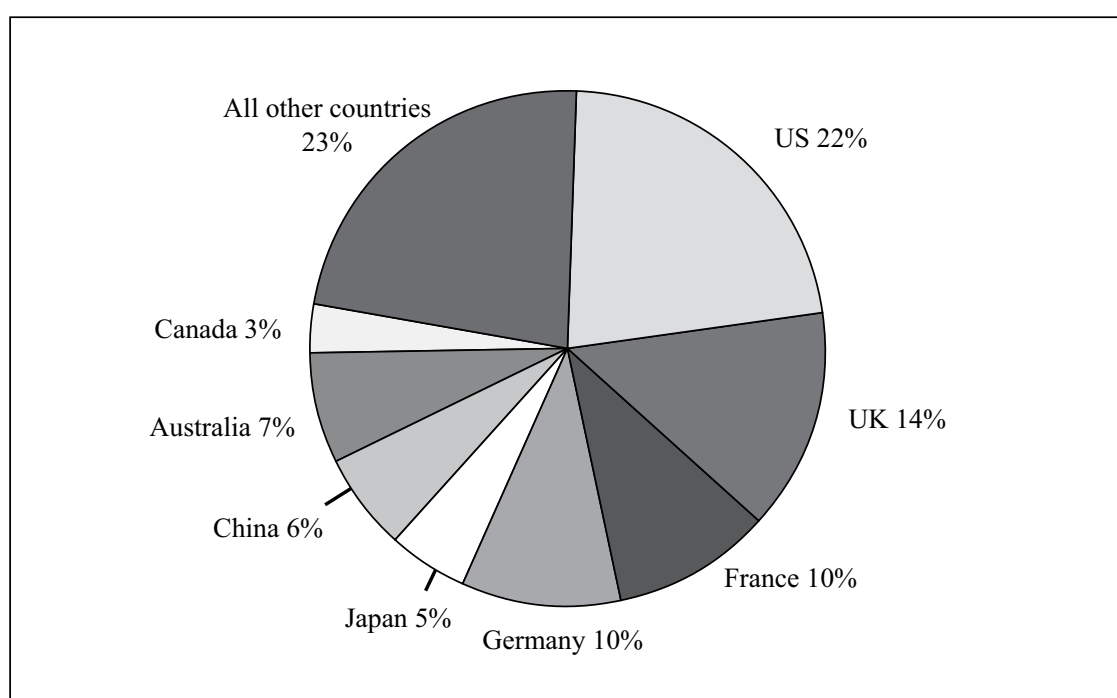


Figure 1.1 UNESCO UIS database, 2006 and *Open Doors 2006: Report on International Educational Exchange at the Tertiary Level* (“Atlas”)

suggesting that Chinese students are on the move across the globe. In the last decade especially, China itself has become an increasingly popular destination: in 2001, 61,869 university students from abroad went to China; in 2004 that had grown to 110,844 undergraduate and graduate students; and by 2005 that had increased still further to over 140,000 students (Slethaug 2007, 4; “Atlas”).

Often people think that international education consists mainly of university students going abroad, and, as my statistics above might suggest, it often concerns such destinations as Australia, China, the UK, and the USA. Certainly, these countries are especially important because they are increasingly geared up to accept international students; as a case in point, the University of Southern Queensland has embraced transnational pedagogy as its operative mode (Dashwood et al. 2008) to be better equipped to deal with international students and the global educating process. Students of Chinese ethnicity from mainland China, Hong Kong, Malaysia, Singapore, and Taiwan make up such a large percentage of international students that they are studied as a special group classified as “Chinese learners,” although that term is not always restricted to learners from those countries.

However, another part of the equation is the number of students, including Chinese learners, who also go into private school systems internationally. This has become big business in many countries as boarding schools have grown steadily and international schools exponentially. Boarding schools have an interesting history, and, though begun during the Middle Ages for boys to be sent to monasteries and noble houses for education, they became highly popular during the colonial period when senior administrators and civil servants and well-to-do business families sent their children home to boarding schools in the UK or Europe to be educated. In that sense, boarding schools have been internationalized for some time, but, in another sense, they were designed to teach the students in a very European way and to educate them in all of the best habits and customs of their home countries, especially Great Britain. They did not exist to promote multiculturalism, and all but a few students in the UK had British heritage.

The breakdown of the colonial system after World Wars I and II put financial pressure on these schools, but that slack has been taken up recently by students coming from all over the world to be educated in what is considered to be an excellent English-speaking British environment. The schools now are much more multicultural and intercultural than they once were, but their mandate generally is still to teach in the language of the country where the boarding school is located and to educate the students out of the traits and customs of their home countries. Now, especially, they exist as stepping-stones to earn admission to top universities. Many Chinese learners have been sent by their families to the UK from Hong Kong, Singapore, and Taiwan, and some from the mainland have gone

there as well as to Australia and New Zealand and, to a lesser degree, Canada and the United States.

Various websites on boarding schools indicate just what an important business this has become. The website for the UK-based *Boarding Schools Directory & Guide 2007* claims that there are more than 700 boarding schools in the British Isles, and these are estimated to educate over 100,000 students annually, among them an increasingly high number of Chinese learners. The Australian Education Network lists 101 boarding schools (mainly religious-based) throughout various cities in Australia, and they, too, have an increasing number of Chinese learners in their student body. In fact, being geographically closer to Australia than the UK, Asian students from the dominant Chinese cultures do not have to travel so far as the UK and Europe and have the advantages of a dollar valued well below pound sterling or the Euro and generally better weather than the UK — though not necessarily steeped in the same traditions. Canada, too, lists some sixty boarding schools, according to *The Handbook of Canadian Boarding Schools* (Lafortune and Thomson 1999), and they depend on Chinese learners for an increasing portion of their budget.

In contrast to boarding schools, which were located mainly in the country of origin with students traveling back and forth to locations where their parents worked, international schools were designed to cater to students away from their home country and provided schooling where the families lived abroad. In many ways, international schools have functioned in a similar way to those of boarding schools, though they generally do not include bed and board. (Some international schools in Australia and the UK, however, are also boarding schools.) Local schools throughout the British colonial empire, for example, were established to educate the children of junior civil servants, families of missionaries, others who could not afford to send their children abroad, those who disliked the idea of sending their children away, children of mixed marriages, and a few others from the local population. During the colonial period, British-based international schools were funded, in part, by the British government, in part by the employers (if they differed), and in part by the families themselves. In Hong Kong, the English Schools Foundation, begun by the Hong Kong government, first built schools mainly on Hong Kong Island but, increasingly, in Kowloon and the New Territories, creating one of the largest British school systems abroad. The British were by no means the only ones to open up such systems, and the Americans, French, Germans, Japanese, Portuguese, Spanish, and Swiss, among others, developed flourishing schools, so that there are now some 58 international schools in Hong Kong alone, as compared with 64 in all of mainland China and 76 in all of India (“All” 2008).

As with the boarding schools during the colonial period, these international schools were designed to educate students in the languages, customs, habits, and pedagogy of the country of national origin. They were not designed to promote multilingualism, intercultural communications, or multiculturalism and not intended to accommodate local pedagogical and cultural perspectives at variance with those from the home country. They were conceived as outposts of their home countries where their citizens could receive good schooling in a comfortable environment not unlike the one they left.

But something, indeed, has been happening that has altered thinking about international schools. Globalization in the past two decades has radically increased the number of international schools and changed their nature. In 1964, there were only about 50 international schools worldwide, and the majority of expatriate children went to their home countries for education, especially in the boarding schools. In the next thirty years, as more and more families went abroad for work, the tally of international schools rose to some 1,000, with 50,000 teachers and 500,000 students (Hayden and Thompson 1998, 333). That in itself, however, was a relatively modest increase compared with the additional 2,000 international schools that would be built in the next decade and the doubling and tripling in size of existing facilities, bringing the total to 3,000 schools and an estimated two million students by 2005 (Greenlees 2006), well beyond the 100,000 educated annually in the boarding schools of the UK. This break-neck speed has not abated, and new international schools are being planned and built almost on a daily basis, especially in the countries of Southeast and Central Asia, where there is galloping globalization and newfound wealth.

In these last forty years of growth, the target groups of these schools have also changed, as both Chris Forse and Eric Jabal note of Hong Kong (Chapters 3 and 4 in this volume). With the demise of colonial empires following World Wars I and II and with the handover of Hong Kong and Macau to China, for example, late in the twentieth century, the number and role of colonial administrators and civil servants diminished, so that the schools were not required to serve them in the same way. Moreover, as international trade, development, and finance accelerated, embassies and consulates needed to grow as well, so the children of traders, bankers, investment advisors, and new governmental administrators and trade officers wanted to find schools within the major world cities, but not necessarily those of their home countries. Then, too, with an awareness of the value of high-quality universities and their programs in the developed world, many people in developed and developing countries wanted to create strategies whereby their children had access to these educational opportunities — and they had the money to send them to the ever more costly international schools. Finally, many of the locals who wanted access to international schools did so because they

believed their children could develop a network of relationships and an education that would better serve them in the marketplace (Lowe 2000). Consequently, although many families at one time wanted their children to attend schools that were founded and fostered by their home countries, that was no longer requisite. Irrespective of their national background, people began to look openly for international schools that could offer a certain lifestyle, deliver high-quality education, and educate and train the children in skills for globalization so that they would be assured of getting into the best universities in Australia, Canada, the UK, and the USA. National origin was not the driving concern or, for most, even a consideration as international schools increasingly became “departure lounges” for university destinations (Yamato and Bray 2006, 60). Consequently, whereas in 1960, 70 percent of the students of the students were children of civil servants, missionaries, and traders from the country that founded the schools, by 2005 only 30 percent of the students would fall into that group. Although these examples might suggest that this movement away from national orientation pertains mainly to schools in a de-colonized Asia, this seems to be a universal phenomenon, for the American-based International School of Brussels

is now only 29 percent American, compared with 70 percent 10 years ago — a change in demographics resulting from increased local hiring by U.S.-based global companies. Increased local hiring has also translated into fewer tuitions being paid by employers — only 89 percent now at ISB, and falling, compared with 98 percent a decade ago. (Conlin 2006, 11)

In effect, the student body of older international schools has become increasingly denationalized, and newer schools will probably not start out with that firm national base (or ideological agenda) in any case, so that, of the 14 percent growth of international schools in Asia between 2005–06, few would be fully grounded in the societies of their countries of origin, though many of the teachers would be drawn from those home countries. The rising number of locals in international schools is quite visible in Hong Kong, where local Chinese learners (who might or might not have moved abroad for a while to acquire background and citizenship in other countries) increasingly fill the available positions in international schools, so that in the Canadian International School, for example, almost all of the students can be classified as Chinese learners, whether or not they have spent some time abroad. As Martin Schmidt notes in Chapter 5 of this book (“Educating Chinese Learners for Social Conscience in Hong Kong: An International School Perspective”), some 80 percent of the students in the Hong Kong International School (the principal American-based school in Hong Kong) are now of Asian descent and the majority of those with Chinese ethnicity. These figures are reinforced by those provided by Chris Forse and Eric Jabal of the ESF

system (Chapters 3 and 4 of this volume), who maintain that spaces once allocated to expatriates are increasingly taken up by local students in Hong Kong.

Many of the local parents prefer to have their children educated in these Western-style, English-speaking classrooms and live close to home at the same time so that they do not become too socialized in liberal Western ways. According to Camilla Russell (2005) in speaking of Thailand, “parents complain about their international school-educated children ‘acting like Westerners.’” She adds, “how then to encourage children to be bilingual while maintaining a strong sense of cultural identity?” (19). In countries such as Indonesia, Singapore, and Malaysia, the locals have not been allowed to attend international schools, but, in most countries, students are free to enroll in any school, so long as they meet the admission requirements and pay the tuition, but many struggle with maintaining their local identities in the face of the socializing processes that are identified with internationalization:

Wide-ranging social, economic, and technological changes have markedly affected educational policy and practice. Globalization . . . has also led to the devaluing of traditional values. In many regions of the world, there is tension between a culture promoted by globalization and that of traditional culture. (Rao, Ng, and Pearson 2009, 257)

However, this tension may not just involve general social processes but specific pedagogical and moral values as well. Li (2009) observes that teaching moral development is a very important part of Chinese pedagogy (49–50; Chan and Rao 2009, 326) — one that could be sadly missed in a Western classroom — and Carol Chan (2009) remarks that too little attention “has been given to detailed analyses of how . . . [global educational values] can be implemented in the Chinese classroom, negotiating the tensions between cultural beliefs, contextual demands and Western ideas” (173). This last observation raises the question of the relationship between the international school and the local community, and, according to Tristan Bunnell (2005), most locals do not know much about, and may not even like the idea of, international schools (Bunnell 2005, 56). Too often they are completely separate entities.

This new denationalized, multinational, and usually bilingual or even trilingual classroom has profound implications for education. First, a broader target group allows the school to grow well beyond a size required to serve only those from its country of origin, and, as a consequence, they are now faced with “staggering demand” (Greenlees 2006, 18). It also means that, if the school is serving a wider clientele than its own countrymen, the schools cannot ask for, or depend upon, their home governments or key national corporations for appreciable support. That, too, creates another requirement — the school has to charge the

students full fees rather than relying upon government and corporate support, in effect meaning that international schools cater to an elite group and increasingly participate in global fiscal competition or suffer systemic under-funding. As an example, annual fees in Hong Kong range from US\$10,000 to US\$20,000, and, to stay in business, schools have to view their students as clients, for whom they provide a range of services and ensure certain standards of education:

Perhaps more than most mainstream schools, therefore, international schools must orient themselves to the market. They must provide curricula that are in demand at a price that can be afforded by their target clients, and must pay attention to changing demographic and economic forces. (Yamato and Bray 2006, 60)

These high fees mean that the students more than likely come from upper and upper middle-class homes, compromising some of the diversity that has become a very positive part of international education.

Despite the drawback of being based on an elitist class structure, international schools' becoming more diverse and multicultural simultaneously challenges and provides opportunities for teachers and students, who will be required to confront and accommodate their differences more directly. This mix of students from different backgrounds and countries also means that schools have to rethink their curricula and perhaps even their pedagogical assumptions. No longer can they be so easily grounded in the affairs of their country of origin. This is particularly true in countries like Australia, which increasingly "attracts a vast number of Asian students from predominantly non-English-speaking backgrounds. Traditionally, low English communication skills are recognized as obstacles to student learning and participation in management programmes," but this also "impacts on the effectiveness of action learning of professional skills," including writing, presenting, speaking out, and working in teams (Soontiens 2004, 301–302). Another side to this question concerns the skills various students bring that could be used to create a stimulating and positive learning environment.

The issue of language cannot be separated from the cultivation of other learning skills, but there are other issues of personal and national identity as well. For instance, the increasing number of Chinese learners put pressure on the Canadian International School in Hong Kong to drop its Ontario civics course, which seemed irrelevant to those who likely would never live in Canada. As John Phillips remarks, "As national boundaries give way to the pressures of the global economy, such notions of citizenship lose their relevance" (Phillips 2002, 171). This view is supported by Janette Ryan (Chapter 2 in this volume), who finds that teachers in Australia, New Zealand, and the UK have also felt pressure to internationalize their curricula and move away from more local and national

concerns and issues. Chris Forse, too, notes that in Hong Kong international schools, the official Chinese language (Putonghua) has been introduced so that the Chinese students can be bilingual, if not exactly biliterate, and that has meant restricting or eliminating other subject areas. In that way, rightly or wrongly, the presence of certain groups can reconfigure the classroom and curriculum. In addition, because the students' goal might not necessarily be to get into a particular national university (e.g., Canadian) but another one in Hong Kong, the UK, or the USA, narrow national curricula might seem too confining, so many schools are changing to the International Baccalaureate system (IB) that has fewer national markers than do national curricula.

International Baccalaureate programs, international schools of education, and Chinese learners

Increasingly popular as an educational tool of global education — and especially for Chinese learners in Hong Kong, mainland China, Singapore, and Taiwan, the IB programs from primary through secondary are specifically designed for international schools with transferability in mind (Carber 2004, 340). Drawn from the practices of several international schools, they are now used as the primary programs of instruction in an increasing number of international schools as well as national schools from kindergarten through secondary schools. The IB website states that as of 2009 there are more than 709,000 IB students in 2,609 schools in 135 countries (“International”), including 994 in the United States, 698 in Africa/West Asia/Middle East, 362 in the Asia Pacific region, and 254 in Latin America. This is up significantly from statistics on their website in 2008, when they tallied 596,000 IB students at 2,218 schools in 125 countries (“International”). These figures register their rapid growth and suggest that more than one quarter of international schools use the IB curricula. It is also important to emphasize that this is a Western curriculum, so that these schools may be international in location, but there is Western ideological construct at work.

One of the principal reasons that educators and parents like the IB program is that it attempts to be ideologically neutral. James MacDonald of the Yokohama International School maintains that the “growth and success” of the IB program is “linked to globalization,” but “not driven by economic factors and is free from the dogma of politics and religion” (“Lifelong” 2007, 11). This means that it is adaptable to national schools but does not require any particular national creed or faith agenda, though it can be argued that teaching in English and requiring English-learning proficiency is certainly ideological — but that is almost a given requirement for the majority of international schools. Still, at least one teacher, Barry Drake from the Chinese International School in Hong Kong, has raised

questions about taking this program with its Western, Anglo roots directly into Asian schools that do not have the same cultural foundations because the emphasis on “multiple perspective taking and open-mindedness” and assumptions about teaching methods to achieve this can create tensions (Drake 2004, 189, 195). At stake here are issues about the effectiveness of global teaching methods in the Asian and European classroom (Ryan 2002; Slethaug 2007) and the degree to which these international schools are truly cross-cultural in recognizing both local and global values. Obviously, this is an issue that needs ongoing engagement by all international schools.

According to the IB website, its “three programmes for students aged 3 to 19 help develop the intellectual, personal, emotional and social skills to live, learn and work in a rapidly globalizing world” (IB 2008). It is probably not accidental that this mission statement is akin to the explicit goals of the OECD in trying to help its member countries develop strong patterns of education in the schools. IB emphasizes the same three skill sets identified by the OECD — that is, reading literacy, science literacy, and mathematics literacy, but also stresses the students’ creative development and direct involvement in the ways that these are taught.

In the reading literacy area of the senior Diploma Program, IB requires a working knowledge of two languages, and in the mathematics area a working knowledge of mathematics and computers. They also require students to gain competence in writing, demonstrated by an extended research essay of 4,000 words for diploma completion. In addition, there is a social science component identified as “individuals and societies,” stressing identity formation as well as comprehension of the larger society. Students must take a “Theory of Knowledge” course that requires them to reflect philosophically on a variety of intercultural modes of gaining knowledge (sometimes even classroom methodologies), and the program also gives students the opportunity to develop and express themselves through a variety of arts activities, including music, drama, and sports. This incorporation of the arts has long been a tradition in the West, but it resonates in many other areas, including China, where there is a growing interest in the liberal arts. In addition, it has a strong service component, the so-called Community Action Service (CAS) that requires students to be involved in initiatives of service to the community. As Martin Schmidt and Zhu Weibin remark (Chapters 5 and 9 in this book), Chinese students in schools and universities are not used to thinking about service to the community as an important feature of an educational system and so can profit considerably from that inclusion. An illustration by the IB Organization indicates an education program that tries to give diversity and unity at the same time (see Figure 1.2 on p. 34).

One of the features of the IB Diploma Program is the combined marking — by internal and external markers — of students’ work in literature, language,

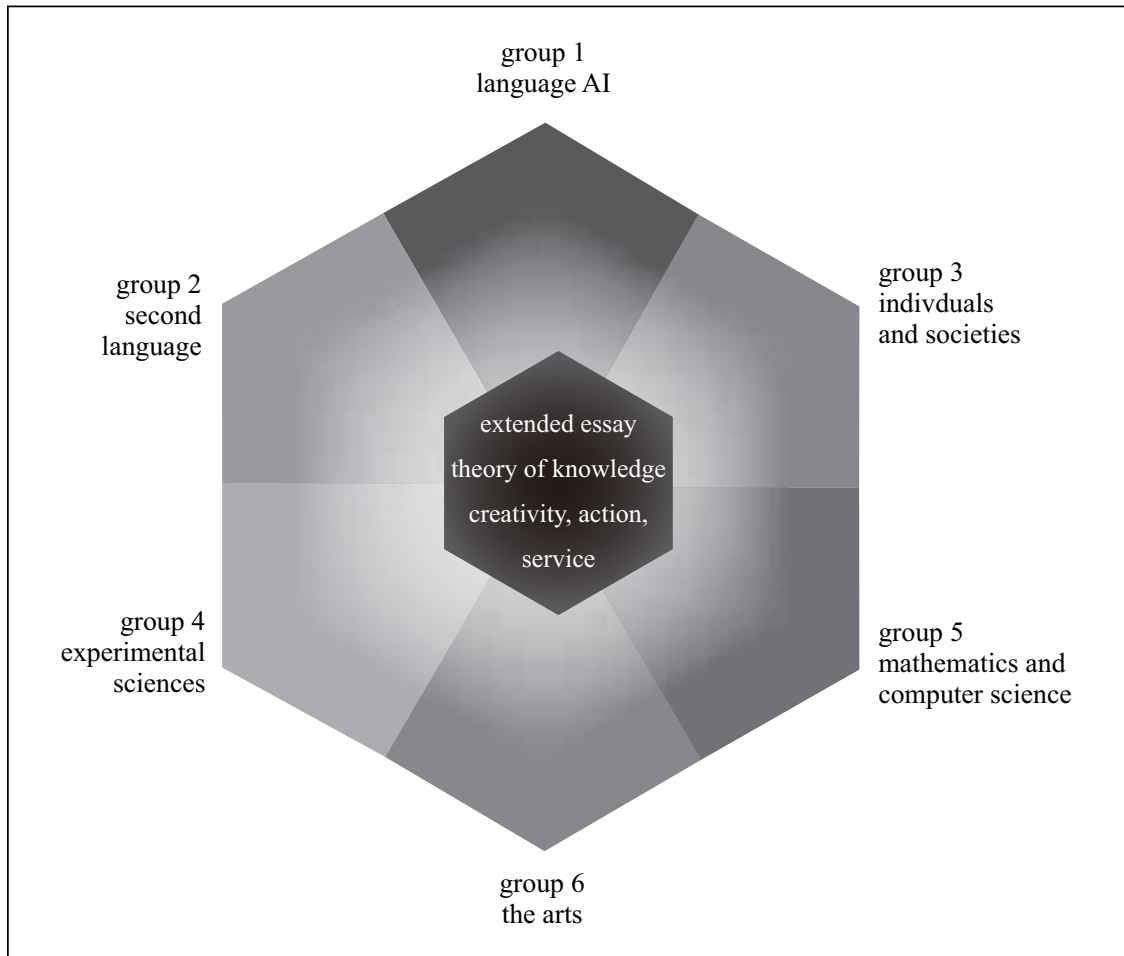


Figure 1.2 Illustration from IB Diploma Program website (2009)

and theories of knowledge. Long a feature of particular European countries and British education in the colonies, this marking procedure links schools and ensures similar standards across the international spectrum. Grade inflation has been a marked problem across the globe, and this is one attempt to keep that problem at bay and convince universities that students graduating from these schools have fair assessments and superior qualifications. This emphasis on a superior education gives the IB program a particular cache as local schools in many countries are perceived as struggling to maintain standards.

When international schools join the IB Organization and teach that curriculum, they have access to assistance from the head offices through the Online Curriculum Center, visits from representatives from the home office, as well as special seminars on teaching. They can also apply to become an assessor in establishing criteria for demonstrated excellence in studying and teaching and can help train others as well. This feature actually goes to the heart of a major problem of teaching in international schools — there are very few university resources and programs dedicated to this issue for “something happened while nobody was looking,” that is, international schools have developed at a supersonic rate

without schools of education addressing possibilities for international curricula or teaching university students how to teach in international schools.

Because education has traditionally been administered and funded on local and regional bases, few have paid attention to new administrative and financial difficulties facing international schools or to new teaching tasks and assignments that internationalization and globalization have inaugurated. Nor have they paid attention to a likely need for a different kind of teaching given the movement of curriculum and student bodies away from a national focus. If most of the students in the school are not of the nationality that the name, banner, and reputation the school celebrates, and if adjustments are made in the curriculum in favor of internationalization, then it follows that pedagogy itself needs “re-view and re-orchestration.”

Reviewing and re-orchestrating teaching, however, is more difficult to address presently than is internationalizing the student body and curriculum because there are so few programs that actually focus on international education. In Europe and the UK, only the University of Bath’s Centre for Education in an International Context, Oxford Brookes Centre for Educational Management (OXCEM), and the University of Cambridge International Examinations (International Teacher Certificate) actually have programs designed for international teaching. The USA, likewise, has few programs dedicated to international teaching. The few that do exist include: Michigan State University (Studies in Education Overseas); Endicott College (MEd in International Education) in Beverly, Maine; George Mason University (Center for International Education) in Fairfax, Virginia; and the School for International Training in Brattleboro, Vermont that has courses on campus and online.

This lack of perspectives and models of international education allows provincial and national ideologies to dominate. This can be problematic for it means that intellectual colonialism is always at work, ignoring the teaching and learning strengths represented by the communities of the students themselves or not trying to construct new models that will incorporate different national pedagogical strengths and models. This also can mean that stereotypes from previous periods about Chinese and other kinds of learners can be perpetuated in the global community, inhibiting creative teaching and learning (Ryan, Chapter 2 in this book). Training in multiculturalism — which is usually a feature of education programs in many countries — is not the same as the teachers’ having to reckon with, and accommodate themselves to, completely different cultures so that everyone in the classroom, including the teachers, has a negotiated space and so that international education will have a chance to become something extraordinary (Slethaug 2007). Erika Schwindt found this lack of “international experience” a serious handicap among German teachers at international schools

in Germany because they had never had “to adjust to different lifestyles over an extended period of time” and never had to change their “perceptions of home” (Schwindt 2003, 77). As Jane Vinther, Jennifer Miller, Ivy Wang, and Zhu Weibin suggest (Chapters 6–9 in this book), part of the excitement and joy of the international classroom is being able to reassess conventional pedagogies and styles to better incorporate the groups that are actually taking the courses.

That, however, can have a downside as well. In the case of the Chinese learners, this can mean that only one kind of Chineseness might be considered (Ryan, Chapter 2 in this book) or that their Chineseness — whatever that represents — can be ignored in favor of the individual, family, and pedagogical values of the country of origin of the teachers. Chinese learners from mainland China do not want it to be assumed that they have the same identity, values, and preferences as Chinese learners from other parts of the world or even that all learners in China are the same, because they vary widely by region, age, gender, religion, and economic and culture status (Hu 2003; Louie 2005; Shi 2006).

In short, the complexity of international education in this age of globalized learning and the complexity of Chinese learners inside and outside of China in many different countries and contexts need a great deal of further study to get a better mix of the global and local, and this is the intention of the following chapters in this book on *International Education and The Chinese Learner*.